Deen Dayal Upadhyaya. We do training from gram panchayat to pradhans to MPs.'[97] In the institute's garden is a corner where visiting BJP dignitaries plant saplings. There were saplings planted by visiting top leaders from Nagaland, by the then chief minister of Uttarakhand, Ramesh Nishankh Pokhariyal, and by the then chief minister of Karnataka, B.S. Yeddyurappa.

The rest of the year, the institute runs its own courses and corporate training programmes. The week I was there, for example, it was hosting executives from three separate companies for training retreats. Its dining halls cooked separate menus on demand for each of the corporate contingents. Prabodhini also runs a start-up incubator, the Atal Incubation Centre, a postgraduate programme in leadership politics and governance managed by its Indian Institute for Democratic Leadership as well as other educational initiatives on leadership. The students I encountered had all enrolled for the postgraduate programme. There was a medical doctor and several executives with about three–four years of experience, all of whom had taken time off from work and wanted to engage with politics.

The manner in which Prabodhini was created and how it grew is illustrative of the fact that the BJP's focus on training its cadres and on historical documentation is not new. It dates back to the early 1980s. Named after veteran BJP parliamentarian Rambhau Mhalgi, Prabodhini was the brainchild of the late BJP leader Pramod Mahajan, who was also its first chairman.[98] The 15-acre campus—more a high-end resort with a swimming pool than a paathshala—is part of a wider 215-acre complex that also contains several Sangh-related institutes: a gaushala (cow shelter), an Ayurvedic centre and an institute for agricultural research. Prabodhini was originally set up in 1982, and moved to its present campus in 1999. In 2003, construction work on the campus was completed, and it was formally inaugurated by the then prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee.[99]

At the heart of this complex lies a vast library named after B.R. Ambedkar, with a meticulously kept archive of well-preserved BJP documents, many of which animate this book. Used as I am to visiting political party offices, the functionaries of which often have little sense of history, I found the Prabodhini archive's professional